APT35 Attack on Water Infrastructure (OT/ICS)



1- **Threat Actors:** APT35 is also known by names such as Mint Sandstorm, and the attacker behind the threat is CyberAv3ngers, one of the factions affiliated with the Iranian Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).

2- **Target: Companies & Infrastructures:** Targeting the Municipal Water Authority of Aliquippa (MWAA) and other critical water facilities, where Industrial Control System devices (Unitronics Vision PLCs) and integrated screens (HMIs) manufactured by the Israeli company Unitronics were accessed.

3- **Attack Method:** Discovering internet-exposed devices using the Shodan search engine for companies and organizations using Unitronics systems, then accessing them by exploiting default factory passwords (such as 1111) that were not changed by system administrators.

4-Global World :
-Cyberconflict & Cyberpower :A political cyber conflict demonstrating how threat actors used basic tools to disrupt critical U.S. infrastructure.

-Cybercrime Laws: Lacking extradition treaties, the U.S. filed criminal charges via Interpol, while OFAC imposed sanctions and added CyberAv3ngers to the SDN List.

5- Risks & Mitigation:
-Operational Risks:Disabling HMI screens and losing real-time system visibility forced operators into manual control to prevent potential water contamination or supply interruption.

-Security Measures:Change default factory passwords on all PLCs, isolate OT systems from the public internet using firewalls/VPNs, and deploy specialized OT monitoring tools.